Gym Class – Worst Game in the World

By Paul Feig

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to Middle School Gym Class! A time ripe with embarrassment! Admit it. You remember – Showering with a group of vicious peers -- Gym clothes that could stand on their own because no one EVER took them home to be washed. But nothing compared to Dodgeball . . . Bombardment . . . Killer . . . No matter what you call it, it is one of those games of childhood that you either loved or loathed. For the athletically superior, it was a chance to prove some semblance of macho superiority. For others, it was little more than an hour of getting mercilessly pummeled by flying rubber projectiles. Either way, it's one of those experiences that you don't soon forget. Let's take a look back at this sadistic little part of physical education that left such a lasting impression on many of us.

Gym Class –Worst Game in the World from Kick Me: Adventures in Adolescence by Paul Feig

FIEG: (Pgs 121-139) There was one class that I never enjoyed, that I faced each day with stomach-twisting dread: gym class. I must admit that I didn't mind gym class as much when I was in grade school because, back

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then, it was literally just running around. We pretty much played easy games and never really worked up a sweat. And for that reason we were allowed to do it all in our school clothes.

When I got to junior high, however, I was confronted with something that I found quite disturbing -- gym clothes. You see, being told I had to wear gym clothes in PE class meant I had to change into them in front of my classmates. And this was not something that I wished to do. At all.

See, I was an only child, and so I never had to take my clothes off in front of anybody. Even my parents. Even when I took a bath, a thick layer of Mr. Bubble, my bath time guardian, made sure my in-tub nakedness would be hidden from any prying eyes. And then suddenly, thanks to a guy named Mr. Wendell, our new gym teacher, I was expected to show 100 percent of myself to a bunch of kids I had grown up with . . . who didn't like me. Where was Mr. Bubble when I needed him?

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WENDELL: *(sounding like a drill sergeant)* All right, ladies. This is the locker room. You'll be changing over in this area, where the lockers are. And over here are the showers. Each of you will be required to shower after every class. No exceptions.

FEIG: I figured I must have died and gone to hell. That could be the only excuse for someone's telling me I was going to have to bathe in public. I take a shower every morning before I go to school. I shampoo and blow-dry my hair. I brush my teeth. I'm the cleanest seventh grader this school has ever seen. He can't possibly be talking to me. *(to Mr. Wendell)* Do we ***all*** have to shower?

NORMAN: Of course you do. What do you want to do? Stink all day?

WENDELL: All right, boys. Change into your gym clothes. We're gonna have a little fun on your first day.

FEIG: I guess I must have had an abnormal amount of hang-ups for a 12-year-old, because no sooner were the words "***change into your gym clothes"*** out of Mr. Wendell's mouth than all my classmates just dropped

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their pants and changed. None of them really seemed to care that they were standing around in front of each other in their underwear. It was clear [that] I was going to have to put my modesty on hold and change in front of this group of alpha males. I let my mind remove itself to somewhere more pleasant as I took off my pants. And as soon as they were off, my face went white. I had forgotten about something. A few weeks earlier, my mother had gotten into a hobby called Cameo, which was the art of drawing designs and pictures on fabric with these special ink pens. And one of the first projects she undertook was to hijack a pair of my underwear and draw a big dark red butterfly right on the back. And that was the pair of briefs I had worn to school this day. I was frozen. Did anyone see it? My mind started to race, in full panic mode.

NORMAN: What is that?!

FEIG: The whole class was moving toward me, staring at the butterfly on the back of my underwear, all of them with stunned, incredulous looks on their faces.

NORMAN: Oh my God. It's a ***butterfly****!*

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FEIG: All hell broke loose. Apparently, they'd never seen decorative underwear and the sight of it had turned them into the kids from ***Lord of the Flies***.

WENDELL: *(entering the locker room angrily)* What the hell's going on in here?!

FEIG: I figured I was saved.

NORMAN: *(pointing at Feig's butt)* Feig's got a butterfly on his underwear!

WENDELL: *(raising an eyebrow)* He does? Let's see it, Feig.

FEIG: So much for being saved. Mr. Wendell leaned over and took a good close look at my mother's handiwork.

WENDELL: A butterfly? That's lovely, Feig. Was it always there or did it use to be a cocoon? *(laughing)* All right, guys, all right, enough of this. Get dressed and get into the gym." *(starting to exit, then turning back to Feig)* Oh, and Feig? You can flutter out with the rest of them.

FEIG: Thanks, Mr. Wendell. You're really an inspiration to us all.

STUDENT 1: Hey, Feig, uh . . . nice ***butt-erfly***

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STUDENT 2: Does your dad have one on his underwear, too?

STUDENT 3: I bet that butterfly . . . uh . . . wishes that it . . . was . . . uh . . . that it didn't have to smell your butt all day.

FEIG: I was the last to finish changing, as I wondered if I could convince my parents to transfer me to an all-girls' school.

WENDELL: All right, everybody, being that this is the first official day of gym, I thought we'd do something a little different. The game I'm going to let you guys play is ... Killer.

FEIG: It was ***not*** going to be something good.

WENDELL: *(pacing in front of the class)* The object of the game is to be the last man left standing. Okay, in order to play Killer, you will be divided into two teams. Each team will take one side of the gym. Then, when I blow the whistle, you will throw the balls across the gym at the other team without crossing the center line. If you are hit by a ball, you're out. If you catch a ball, the person who threw the ball is out. Got it?

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FEIG: Unfortunately, I did. And I realized that this was the last game in the world I wanted to play.

NORMAN: These balls are too big. *(picking up a cantaloupe size rubber ball)* When my brother and I play, we use tennis balls. They really hurt.

FEIG: Yes, I thought, that really does sound like more fun. Maybe if we're really good, one week Mr. Wendell will let us use golf balls and Chinese throwing stars.

WENDELL: *(clapping his hands)* All right, girls, grab a ball and choose a side.

NORMAN: Hey, Butterfly? You're dead!

FEIG: Oh great, I thought. I was about to be the star of my gym class's production of ***The Lottery.*** It was at this moment that I had to reflect on the question: "Exactly why do we ***have*** gym class in the first place?" Was it supposed to build morale? Self-esteem? To make us more confident about our bodies, our minds, and our abilities? That's what my father always told me, but if that was the case, then my school district was failing miserably. [One thing] was clear. Everyone in this gym wanted to see me dead. I guess putting a

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butterfly on your underpants was right up there with defiling the American flag.

Mr. Wendell walked out onto the floor, whistle in mouth. He took a deep breath . . . the whistle blew. And I descended into hell. ***BLAM!*** I suddenly realized that these "harmless" balls were actually lethal weapons, when thrown by my classmates. If competitive sports were supposed to inspire teamwork, then my butterfly underwear had apparently inspired this group of fun-loving lads into a lynch mob.

I knew one thing. I had to keep moving. Fast. *(enacts the game as he speaks)* The balls were coming in at a blinding rate. I ran back and forth with a sort of high-stepping circus-horse gait, arms and legs flailing wildly. Keep moving. Keep moving. That's all my brain could tell me to do. Life hadn't prepared me for this type of evasive action. ***BOOM!*** The next volley came in. I dodged the attack. A few of my "comrades" fell. They had been hit. Ha. I had survived the initial surge. Maybe I would be okay. ***BOOM!*** Another hit. ***BOOM!***

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BOOM! I felt like I was going to puke. ***BOOM!*** Every time I looked around, I noticed that more and more of my teammates were gone, taken out by the Playground Balls of Death. And because of this, I was quickly on my way to becoming one of the last players left, an honor I definitely ***didn't*** want. Something had to be done.

Karl Scott was throwing the large ball at our team and then letting it rebound back to him. I figured that once that ball hit the bleachers, its velocity would be decreased, and I could then step in front of it and stop it from rebounding back across the gym. So, I ran in to get it. Karl Scott saw me coming.

KARL: You're dead, big-nose!

FEIG: He heaved the ball and I ducked at the last minute. ***BOOM!*** Great. This wasn't working. ***BOOM!*** He threw again. And again I ducked and let it go by. ***BOOM!*** Karl missed again. He was definitely getting frustrated now.

KARL: Give up . . . You know you're gonna get it.

FEIG: *(with a false sense of bravado)* From you, Karl? Not

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yet. Not without a fight. *(to audience)* Karl got a look of determination, wound up, and heaved the ball at me again, this time as hard as he could, delivering what he knew would be the Death Blow. The ball came straight toward my face. Suddenly, the world seemed to shift into slow motion. The ball was headed toward me, too fast to dodge, right on course to take my head off. I saw Karl Scott's face over the top of the ball. He had a real smug smile, happy to be the one to bring the Butterfly Boy down.

Then, suddenly, everything went back to normal speed. In a last futile act of self-preservation, I held my hands out in front of me and closed my eyes. I felt the ball break through my fingers, skid down my arms, and explode into my chest. Is this what it's like to be shot? I wondered. The force knocked me right off my feet. I slammed onto the ground, butt first, and hit my back against the wooden beams on the wall. A hot pain ran through my chest where the ball had hit. Everything was spinning from the shock.

Then, I heard something strange. Silence. Absolute

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silence. I looked down and saw that the ball he threw was still lodged between my arms and chest. I had caught it. Karl was out. Because of me, Karl was OUT. Oh my God, I thought, eyes wide. I did it! All right! They gotta respect me for this.

I immediately pictured a scene in the locker room with all of them coming up to me and giving me a "We're sorry we misjudged you, you're really an okay guy" speech and then singing "For He's a Jolly Good Fellow." Maybe they'd even all get butterflies cameoed on their underwear in a show of solidarity. Because, whether they wanted to admit it or not, I had just proven myself.

BOOM BOOM! I was thrown quickly back into reality when two balls slammed into the ground on either side of me. I was now the only one left on my team. Five of the enemy remained, their eyes trained on me. Definitely not the position I had been looking to get into. GET ME OUT OF HERE! They moved closer.

Well, here goes, I figured. I'm gonna get myself out. I threw the ball high in the air, right toward Rick Jones.

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An easy catch, Rick. Just stick out your arms and you'll be the King of the Locker Room. Rick sidestepped out of the way, casually, right at the last moment. Then Rick looked at me and shook his head, scary calm on his face.

RICK: You ain't gettin' out that easy, Feig.

FEIG: Suddenly, I heard a whistle blow. It was Mr. Wendell. He was actually going to stop this. My persecution has ended! The man ***finally*** came through for me.

WENDELL: No borders, boys. The field is open. That means you don't have to stay on your side of the center line. So, c'mon, get in there and let's finish this game up.

FEIG: Oh, ***GREAT***! The time had come. Life as I knew it was about to end. The five mouth-breathers surrounded me. I was dead. I looked over to the sidelines at my classmates, boys with whom I had grown up. I saw Mr. Wendell, the man put in charge of my physical development. I saw them all, the compassionless bunch. Would the sight of a trapped person, a cornered, defenseless animal, stir some sort

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of sympathy within them? There was nothing left to do. I officially hated these guys. I looked right at them. *(breathing heavily, nearly crying, high-pitched)* "YEAH? WELL, F*** *YOU* ALL!

I stood there, panting, trying not to cry. I looked at the five assassins who surrounded me. Rick Jones reached out slowly . . . and lightly touched me on the arm with the ball he was holding.

RICK: *(kindly)* You're out, Feig.

FEIG: *(gulping, chest heaving)* . . . really? . . .

RICK: Uh-huh.

FEIG: *(to audience)* ***B-B-BLAM!!!*** The five surrounding balls exploded into my body. . . Everything went black. When I came to, Mr. Wendell told me I'd be in detention for a week. For swearing.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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